pertaining to the Jain religion. Around 500 A.D. (CE) the Jain *acharyas* (teachers) realised that it was extremely difficult to keep memorising the entire Jain literature complied by the many scholars of the past and present. In fact, significant knowledge was already lost and the rest was tampered with modifications. Hence, they decided to document the Jain literature as known to them.

Five Great Vows of Jainism: 1. Non-violence – *Ahimsa;* 2. Truth– *Satya;* 3. Non-stealing – *Achaurya;* 4. Celibacy/Chastity – *Brahmacharya;* 5. Non-possession – *Aparigraha.*

A major split occurred in Jainism (1st century B.C.), giving rise to two major sects, namely *Digambaras* and *Swetambaras.* Both the *Digambaras* and the *Swetambaras* generally acknowledge the *Agama Sutras* to be their early literature, while they do differ with regard to their content and interpretation.

## Jain Literature

Jain literature is generally classified into two major categories.

### 1. Agama Sutras

Agama Sutras consists of many sacred books of the Jain religion. They have been written in the Ardha-magadhi Prakrit language. Containing the direct preaching of Mahavira, consisting of 12 texts, they were originally compiled by immediate disciples of Mahavira. The 12th Agama Sutra is said to have been lost.

### 2. Non-Agama Literature

Non-Agama literature includes commentary and explanation of Agama Sutras, and independent works, compiled by ascetics and scholars. They are written in many languages such as Prakrit, Sanskrit, old Marathi, Rajasthani, Gujarati, Hindi, Kannada, Tamil, German and English. Recognition was given to 84 books, and among them, there are 41 sutras, 12 commentaries and one *Maha Bhasya* or great commentary. The 41 sutras include 11 *Angas* (scriptures followed by *Swetambaras*), 12 *Upangas* (instructions manuals), five *Chedas* (rules of conduct for the monks), five *Mulas* (basic doctrine of Jainism) and eight miscellaneous works, such as *Kalpasutra* of Bhadrabahu. It is believed that the *Panchatantra* has a great amount of Jain influence.

The *Jainacharitha* of *Kalpa Sūtra* is a Jain text containing the biographies of the Jain Tirthankaras, notably Parshvanatha, founder of Jainism as well as the first Tirthankara, and Mahavira, the last and the 24th Tirthankara. This work is ascribed to Bhadrabahu, who along with Chandragupta Maurya migrated to Mysore (about 296 B.C.) and settled there.

Tirthankaras are those who have attained *nirvana* and made a passage from this world to the next.

In addition to these, we have some Jain texts composed in Indian vernacular languages such as Hindi, Tamil and Kannada. *Jivaka Chintamani,* a Tamil epic poem, is a good example, composed in the tradition of Sangam literature by a Jain saint named Tiruthakkathevar. It narrates the life of a pious king who rose to prominence by his own merit only to become an ascetic in the end. Another scholarly work in Tamil, *Naladiyar,* is also attributed to a Jain monk. *Thirukkural* was composed by Tiruvalluvar, believed to be a Jain scholar.



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